



MALIK: She has won over 15 medals in international swimming and javelin; rode her specially-designed bike for the MTV Roadies; runs own garden restaurant

OLD PROBLEMS

- Lack of official database and vague idea about the number and needs of the disabled in India. Public and private estimates clash.
- Persons with Disabilities (Equal Opportunities, Protection of Rights and Full

Participation) Act lacks teeth; excludes private sector

- No well-defined regulation to make it mandatory for all buildings and transport to be accessible to the disabled
- Conventional attitude. Disability not perceived as a single macro issue.

21 million people in India are disabled, says Census 2001, the first official disability count.

80 million Indians are differently-abled, claim private estimates.

disability. A study stint in the US showed him how much more fulfilling life can be for people like him. He came back and started raising uncomfortable questions: "How many of us are there? Why are we kept out of the Census?" After a long battle, the Government finally yielded and Census 2001 put the figure at 2.13 per cent of India's population. But Abidi, who heads the National Centre for Promotion of Employment of Disabled People, finds the figures debatable. A World Bank report, *People with Disabilities in India*, claimed last year that for every 100 there are about eight dis-

abled people in India. "If you don't see them that's because the system doesn't allow them to be visible," he says.

Unlike Mohit, Shivani Gupta became a wheelchair-user after a car accident at the age of 22, on the eve of leaving for higher studies in the UK. Over the years, struggling with the everyday challenges of taking her life forward, she has grasped the harsh reality: The nation might be on a construction boom but easy access to buildings continues to be overlooked. "Builders install ramps, but in absence of guidelines, those are often all wrong," she says. "We